Academic Pressure and Mental Health in South Asian American High School Students

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As academic expectations keep climbing, mental health has become a growing topic of concern for high school students. Today's students encounter many stressors, from parents, school, and peers, to self-imposed demands to succeed in their education and life after high school. Academic pressure has the potential to be a driving force and encourage individuals to be motivated and reach goals, but when it gets too high it can affect emotional well-being, social connections, and the quality of life in general. For a lot of students, especially those who identify with South Asian or South-East Asian cultures, their academic success is linked to their family expectations, cultural values, and future goals. The relationship between academic stress and mental health has been widely researched, and studies have repeatedly reported that academic pressure is associated with anxiety, depression, emotional exhaustion, and a decrease in self-confidence (Jiang et al., 2022; Kristensen et al., 2023). However, many students do not reach out for help because of the stigma that comes with it, the expectation of judgment, or the thought that their academic pressure doesn't qualify as serious stress (Clement et al., 2015). For many in South Asian communities, the cultural norm of valuing educational achievements and family honor adds to these struggles and academic stressors (Rasool et al., 2021).

The purpose of this study was to explore the relationship between academic pressure and mental health of South Asian and South-East Asian high school students. Furthermore, this study aimed to analyze how cultural and familial factors affect South Asian and South-East Asian students seeking mental health care. By gathering and analyzing data regarding academic pressure, stressors, coping mechanisms, motivation levels, and help-seeking behaviors, we hope to gain insights into how these factors can contribute to and inform effective means of improving student mental health.

Academic pressure is a key influence on adolescent mental health, typically stemming from a mix of parental and school expectations and social pressure or competition (Jiang et al., 2022). Many students have academic demands that they feel the pressure to live up to while at the same time planning for a competitive college experience and life after high school. Students have noted that high levels of coursework and comparisons to successful peers can result in anxiety and an unreasonable expectation of success (Laili Qomariyah et al., 2023). Academic pressure can be detrimental to academic self-efficacy, or a student's perception and belief in their

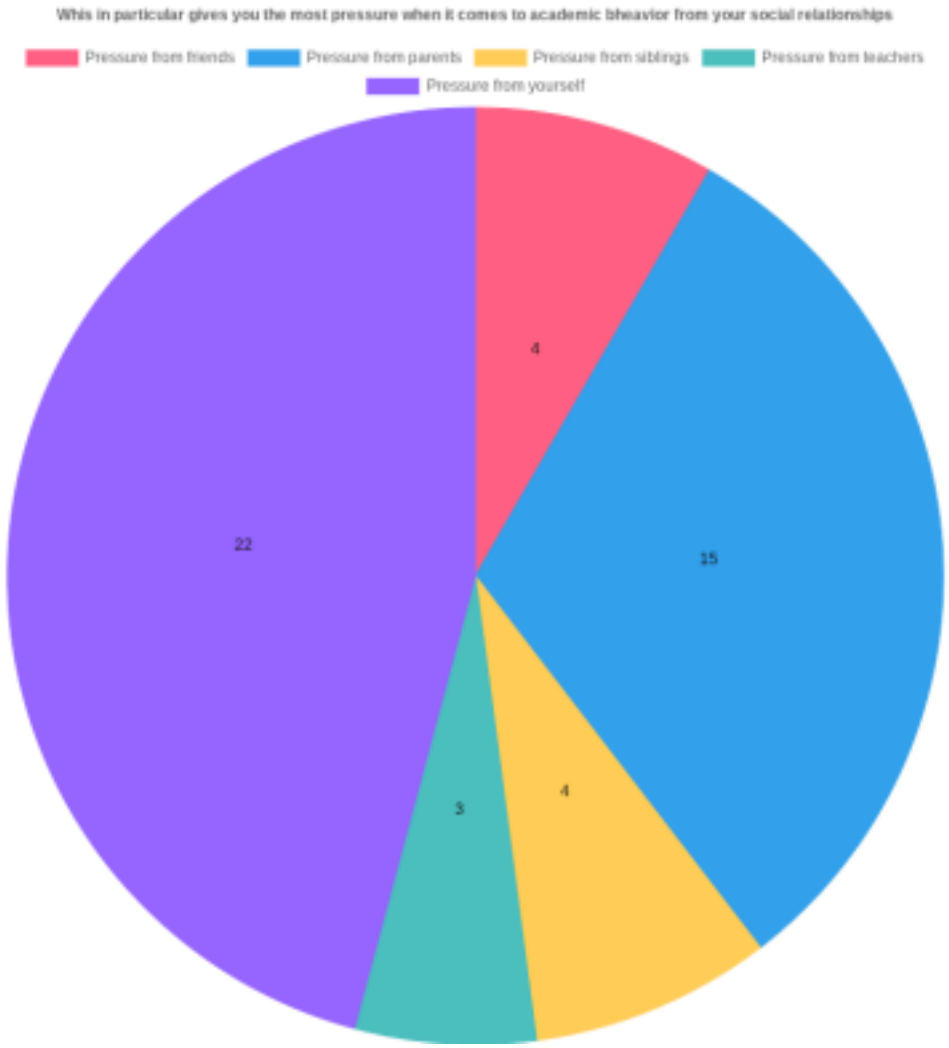
academic capabilities. Prolonged academic stress can undermine students' perception of their own academic self-efficacy, meaning that students may believe they will not do as well or are struggling to achieve academically, thereby reducing their capacity to handle academic stressors or adversity (Kristensen et al., 2023). Research links academic stress and anxiety disorders, depression, exhaustion, social withdrawal, aggression, and suicide ideation (Albro, 2024).

Even with the existence of available support and resources in the school and community, many individuals will avoid asking for help. One such reason is mental health stigma. Research has reported that stigma was identified by around 73% of the individuals surveyed as a barrier to seeking mental health help (Clement et al., 2015). Students may fear that by seeking help they will appear weak to the community, be judged by their peers, or disappoint family members if they acknowledge that they need mental health assistance. Stigma and the desire to not disappoint their families may resonate strongly within South Asian communities as many in the community prioritize and value educational achievement and a successful educational experience as an avenue for financial security, career stability, and familial honor (Rasool et al., 2021). Additionally, the "model minority" label that is often applied to South Asian communities may result in an increase in performance expectations and a decrease in the desire to speak on mental health or emotional challenges within the classroom (Rice, 2017). Consequently, many may feel that academic expectations originate not only from those they interact with but also from internalized cultural norms and standards for themselves.

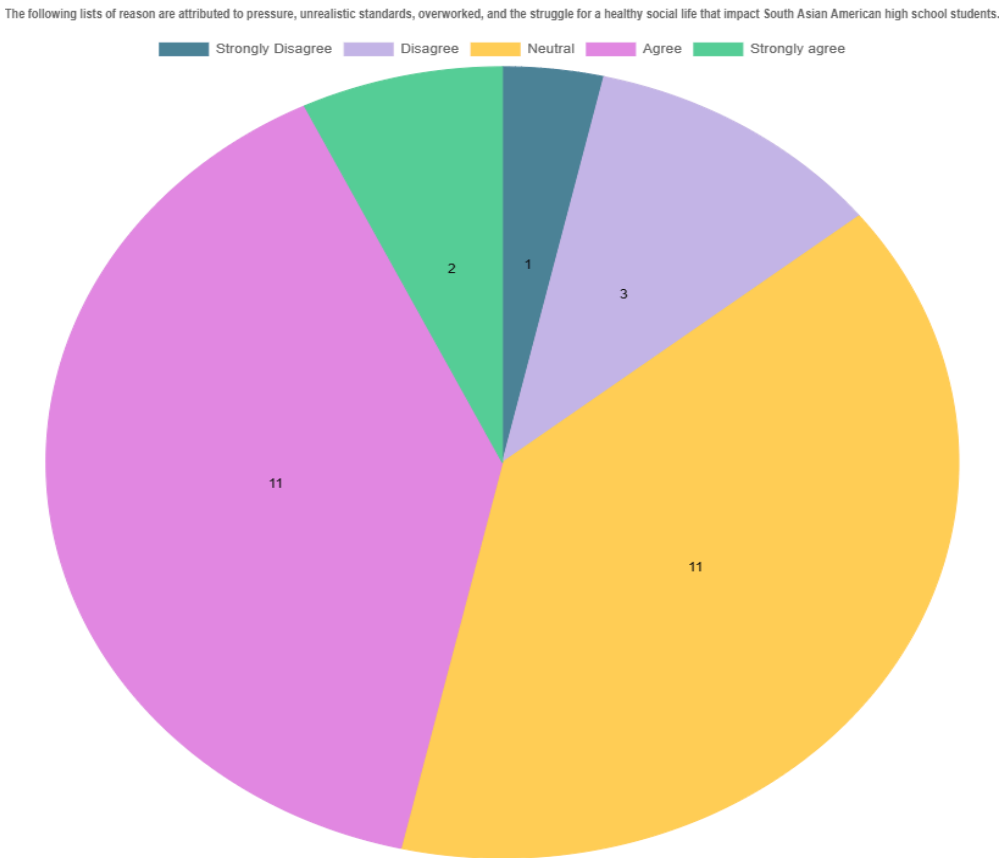
In order to further investigate and understand the link between academic pressure and mental health, I surveyed South Asian and South-East Asian high school students across various cities and towns using a questionnaire that included both quantitative and qualitative data about academic stressors, academic pressure, how students are handling the stress, motivations, and seeking help for mental health. I gathered and analyzed data via survey responses with the help of rating scales and multiple choice questions. Survey data was anonymous to ensure honest and unbiased responses. This included students who live in different geographical areas to increase the reliability and external validity of this study in order to understand the broader population of South Asian and South-East Asian high school students. Data was analyzed in order to look for trends, patterns and associations of the variables that were collected: academic pressure, student's

mental health, and willingness to seek mental health help.

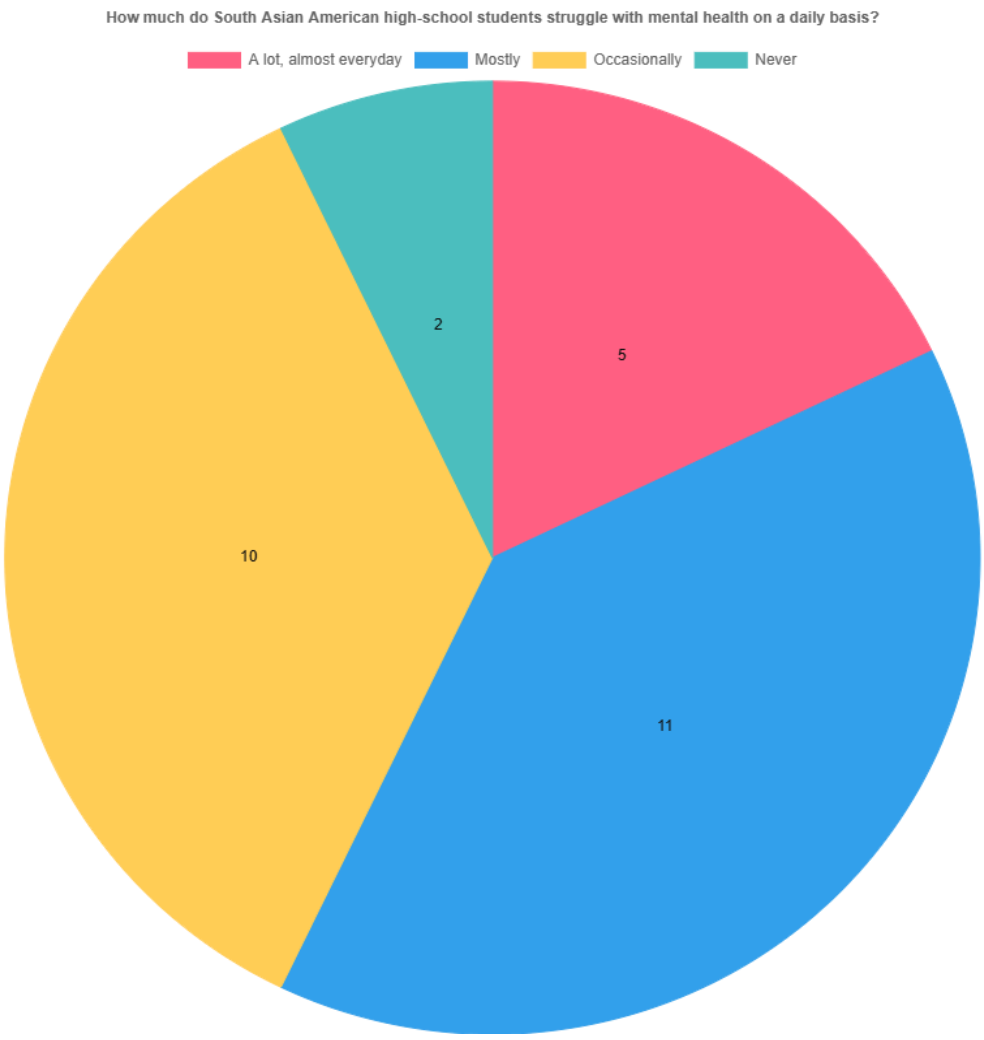
Several important themes emerged from the survey responses: Firstly, there is evidence that students feel the effects of fear of failure and future success more so than the effects of direct pressure from family. While they acknowledge that cultural and family pressure does play a role in their lives, they overwhelmingly identify fear of failure or future success as their stressor.



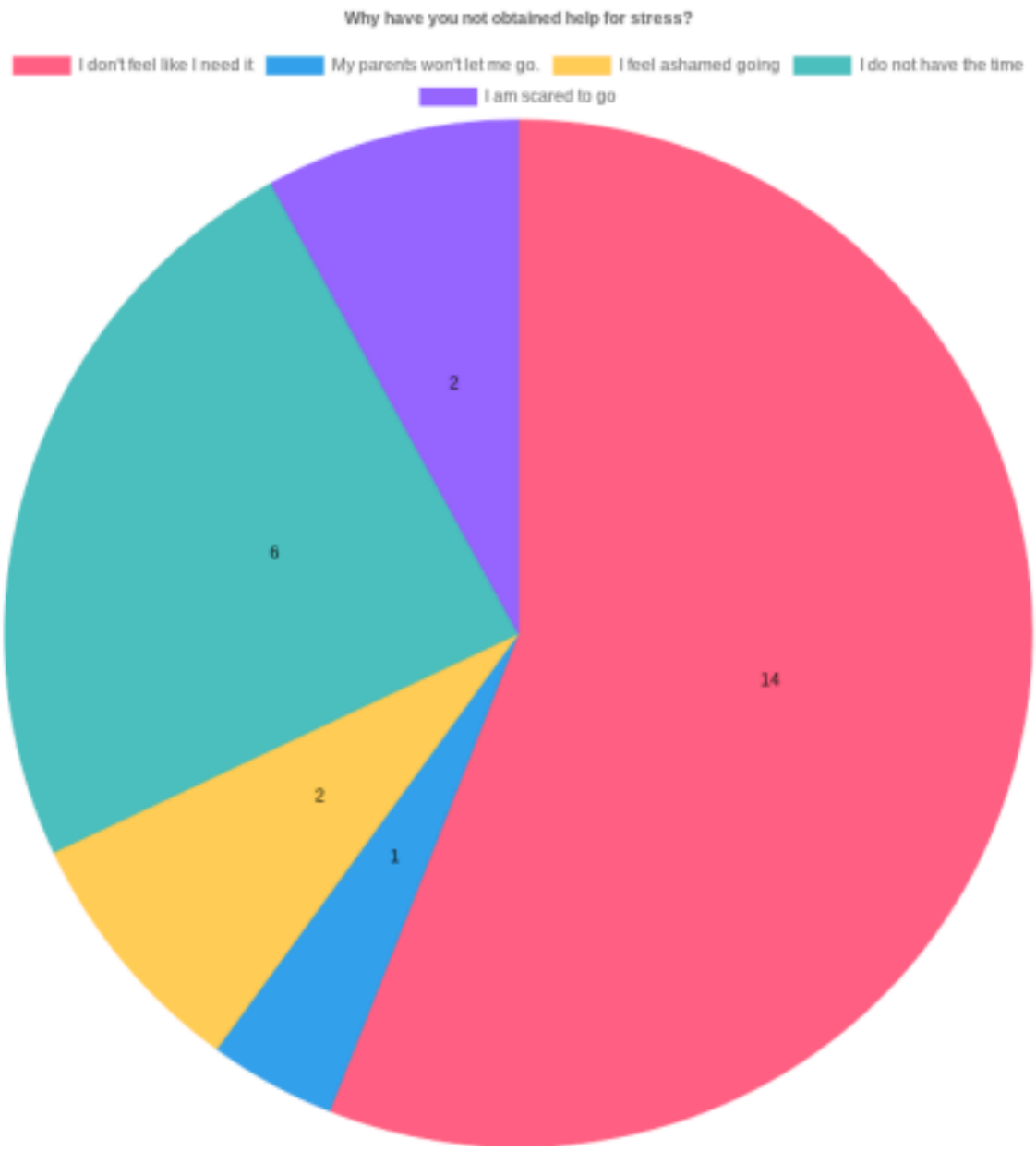
Secondly, it was found that about 46% of students surveyed felt overwhelmed/pressured/confused as a result of academic stress. This means that 46% of students surveyed felt some form of stress regarding academics.



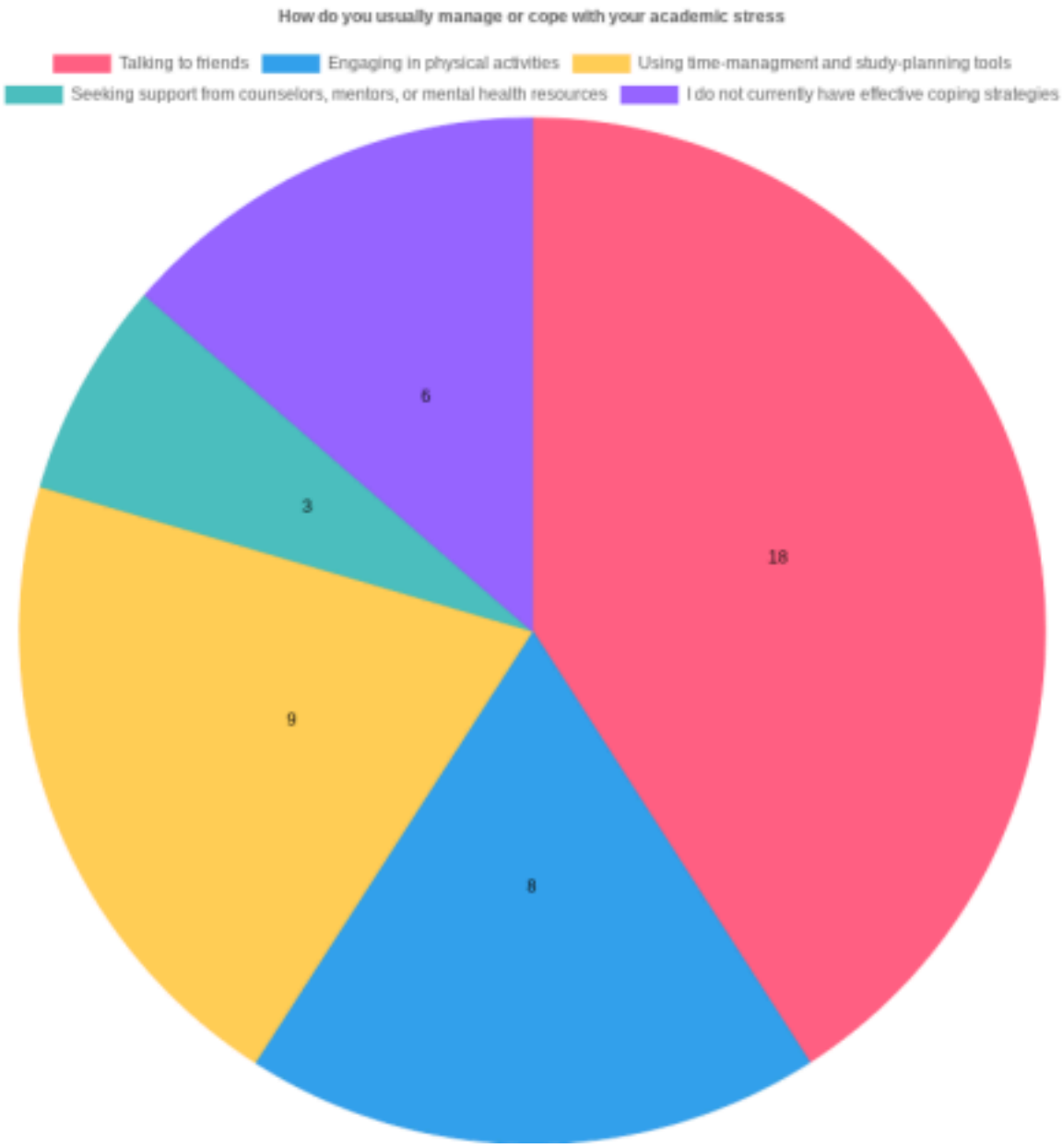
Thirdly, 93% of respondents reported mental health concerns related to stress regularly. This indicates that a great majority of the students who participated in this survey are mentally struggling with stress in relation to academics.



One of the more troubling themes that emerged is that 89% of students surveyed stated they had never sought professional help because they felt they did not need it. This highlights a problem that while students are feeling high stress, they don't realize they should be seeking outside help. It indicates they may be normalizing high levels of stress.



Finally, students stated the most common way they cope with academic stress was by talking to friends/peers.



Findings from this study suggest that academic pressure in South Asian/South-East Asian students works in a double-edged way: On one hand, the research shows that many students use their own and/or their family's expectations as motivation for high achievement, persistence in their field, and setting specific goals. Many students stated that the pressure pushed them to maintain good grades, pursue more opportunities, and have a stronger work ethic.

On the other hand, academic pressure may have detrimental mental health effects for these students. While many of our students may be achieving, many of them are not feeling mentally healthy as a result. When students always feel like their parents and themselves are expecting them to be at their absolute best all the time, many are willing to give up anything, including sleep, relationships, and happiness, in an effort to please themselves and others.

One of the most notable points to be considered is the finding that it appears to be fear of failure more than explicit parental/family expectations that students feel stress from. While research has emphasized that the influence of culture and family does play a significant role in Asian/Asian-American students' academic stress, this survey suggests that many students may internalize family and societal expectations, which would still cause stress even when these expectations are not explicitly stated to them at all.

It is also important to consider the finding that the majority of students reported that they felt stressed but that 89% of the students said they would not seek help, because they felt they did not need it. This suggests that more needs to be done to make Asian/Asian-American students aware that the pressure they experience may not be "healthy" or that it is okay to seek help, even when the stress they are feeling is not related to school.

Overall, these results align with existing literature and emphasize the role of perceived pressure, self-pressure, and fear of failure as important contributors to academic stress. Survey results suggest several evidence-based recommendations that can help improve student mental health and mitigate the negative effects of academic pressure:

- Establish peer support programs: Given that students tend to turn to friends and classmates first for support, schools should develop structured peer support programs where students can share about academic stressors and coping mechanisms, hold regular meetings where students can talk about challenges, and work towards breaking the feeling of isolation.

- Implement student mentorship programs: Pairing up younger students with older ones who have navigated academic pressure can provide mentorship and guidance. Mentors can help students normalize the topic of stress while also offering practical advice for managing stress and balancing academics with other aspects of their lives.

- Integrate mental health education: Mental health literacy should become a part of school curriculum, where students can learn about recognizing the warning signs of long-term stress, anxiety, and burnout, as well as the conditions under which they may benefit from professional help.

- Work towards destigmatization: Schools and communities can work on destigmatizing mental health conversations by launching awareness campaigns, guest speaker events, and workshops, along with student-led initiatives. Normalizing discussions around mental well-being can help students feel comfortable seeking help.

- Improve access to mental health services: Access to counselors should be highly visible and easily accessible, with students informed about the services on offer and the importance of seeking support.

- Promote healthy notions of success: Schools and families should work on helping students find ways to define success that go beyond academic performance by promoting the importance of personal growth, resilience, mental well-being, and balance, which can help curb unhealthy perfectionism and unrealistic expectations.

This study sought to explore the impacts of academic pressure on the mental health of South Asian and South-East Asian students in high school. The results of the study found that while academic pressure plays a motivating role for many, it can be a major stressor for others. While the students who participated in the study generally noted that academic pressure contributed to better grades, achieving their goals, and setting their sights on bright futures, a

significant portion reported experiencing mental health symptoms such as stress, exhaustion, and compromised well-being.

Notably, most participants reported that they were more affected by fears of failure, future academic, or career plans than family expectations. This suggests that for most, academic pressure is internalized and may be leading students to put inordinate demands on themselves. Another key finding was that the vast majority of students who had experienced mental health symptoms as a result of stress had not sought any form of professional help, highlighting the need to raise awareness about mental health services and intervene early.

As academic competitiveness continues to grow, it will be increasingly important for students, schools, families, and communities to collaborate in caring for students' mental well-being. By fostering open dialogue, encouraging peer networks, working to reduce stigma, and facilitating access to resources, schools can create an environment where students can pursue academic success without sacrificing emotional well-being. Success, in the end, should not just mean academic achievement, but maintaining a healthy, fulfilling, and balanced life.

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